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Between Traditionalism and Modernism

Approaches to a Vernacular Architecture

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Dennis Alan Mann received his B. Arch from the University of Cincinnati and his M. Arch from the University of Pennsylvania in 1966. He has been teaching at Cincinnati since 1967. He has published *The Arts in a Democratic Society* as well as a number of articles surrounding the ideas of popular culture and its relationship with architecture.

*In a couple of years they have built a home sweet home
With a couple of kids running in the yard
of Desmond and Molly Jones*
Lennon and McCartney

Introduction

Listening to these lyrics made me wonder what that home of the hard-working Desmond and his pretty wife Molly might be like. I imagined that it could be somewhere on the fringes of Liverpool in a semi-rural neighborhood. I even imagined that they had chosen me to be their architect. I had to keep reminding myself that this was not a house for the Kaufmanns or the Steins or for my mother or even for myself. It was a house for the Joneses. Not that they deserve anything less mind you, but wouldn't they want a home that was much like all the other homes in the area where they lived; homes that carried on the traditions and patterns of life of people like themselves?

As an architect and an educator I began to ask myself about the paradigms in education that prepared a student for the task of designing the Jones' house or, for that matter, the neighborhood supermarket, the local shopping mall or the health maintenance clinic out on the bypass. On the one hand, I knew that many of the great monuments of architectural history that I had studied had been built by strongly hierarchical or even slave-labor societies. On the other hand, modern America is a pluralist, consumer-oriented, egalitarian society with a broad base of potential clients. But contemporary architects seemed to me at that time, as now, uninterested in competing with design/builders, developers, the metal-building industry and corporations, all with their own in-house staffs. Furthermore, it was clear that most architectural students were not prepared by the nature of their education to design, let alone understand, any building which was not either historically significant or currently fashionable.

But my own education had not been that different. As a young graduate I felt that my responsibility, my quest, was to move out among the masses to educate their tastes. What I've come to realize is that I meant to impose my tastes on others. John Nichols, a keen observer of the human scene, points out an alternative sensibility. In *Nirvana Blues* he describes Chamisaville, New Mexico, a fictional town sounding much like Taos.

"Old style adobes, favored by Spanish-speaking valley denizens, had been solid, flat-roofed, one-story dwellings, so simple they seemed logical extensions of the earth. Unobtrusive, beautiful, and architecturally similar, for centuries their unpretentious sameness had added to the valley's feeling of community. In contrast, the new houses were explosions of individual expression gone awry. Every house was unique, an extension (call it a flaunting) of its owner's implacable ego. The design idiosyncrasies of each dwelling slobbered all over themselves. If fabricated of adobe, that mud was sculpted in Gaudiesque dribbles. Ramparts, scaffolds, and turrets abounded. At every turn were corbels and arches and cantilevered patios, pyramids and towers ad infinitum. Enormous picture windows framed cinematic and panavistic views of Hija Negrita, the sacred mountain. Greenhouses proliferated like rabbits . . . Two- and three-story frame houses shot toward the heavens like sky-scraperitos, their roofs sheathed in Mediterranean orange terra-cotta."¹

Nichols' perceptions of Chamisaville are not that different from what I've observed in travelling through America. There are regional styles and different patterns of building which are and have been connected to their specific areas in America for generations. (Figs. 1, 2) What makes a place distinct are the unique characteristics of the buildings which allow them to be identified with a place. If these characteristics grow directly from the social and cultural traditions of their residents then it follows that we, as both architects and students of architecture, need to develop paradigms to deal with customary building as well as unique or trend-setting building.

But, is it possible to teach architecture students to design in a regionally sensitive or vernacular way? Does this attitude run counter to the very paradigms that dominate not only the practice of architecture but also architectural education? In spite of stylistic and philosophic changes, the idea of a regional architecture or a vernacular architecture of any sort runs counter to the nature of architectural practice and education (or even perhaps formal education of any kind) in America. Today practice and formal education are bound to the tenets of positivism, idealism and rationalism. These three

Little in the history of the profession of architecture or in our current paradigm of architectural education teaches us to understand architecture from the standpoint of traditional social values. The ideology of modernism, which remains the foundation for the educational philosophy in most architectural schools, is too closely linked with the forces of positivism, idealism and rationalism to respond adequately to the traditional cultural patterns of society. Yet, it is generally felt that it is modernist ideology which pulls us into the future by setting new standards and destroying old icons. In a pluralist and democratic society students of architecture should be equipped with strategies for design which are informed by the ideologies of modernism and traditionalism and with the ability to make judgments as to their appropriate uses.

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forces are intellectual stumbling blocks to a structured approach to the teaching and practice of an architecture based on tradition. Positivism, because it places its faith in observable fact, objectivity and, above all, the preeminence of information, dismisses the subjective values that people bring to all their transactions with architecture. Idealism, because it espouses the artistic and philosophic vision of a higher and purer order, ignores the relative qualities of human experience, qualities based in the here and now. Rationalism, because it promotes a design methodology founded on analyzing "information" and then synthesizing "solutions" from that information, neglects to recognize that design usually happens in a non-linear, conjecture-analysis manner.²

In contrast, the idea of a regional or a vernacular architecture is closely tied to the idea of tradition. Tradition implies a handing down of knowledge, a passing on of doctrine. It is endorsed by sentiment, love, family and community bonds. Tradition is a powerful force not only on but below the surface of our lives. It guides our lives more than we want to believe—even those of us who live in a post-industrial society.

To complicate the argument it should be pointed out that tradition in our society is not the same as that described by Christopher Alexander in *Notes on the Synthesis of Form*. There, traditional design is characterized as accepted beyond question by all builders, connected to building habits dominated by myth and legend, resistant to willful change, and most often user-built.³ More appropriate to the idea of tradition in contemporary life is John Kouwenhoven's definition of what could be termed a dynamic tradition. Kouwenhoven's vernacular arts are "objects shaped empirically by ordinary people in unself-conscious and uninhibited response to the challenges of an unprecedented cultural environment."⁴ These challenges are tied directly to the "twin forces of democracy and technology."⁵

Architects today are not in touch with the traditions that Kouwenhoven describes. Little in the history of the profession or the contemporary philosophy of education teaches us to understand and work with either traditional values or the realities of a democratic society. From a practical standpoint this should be more than apparent. In "The Compensation Crisis"



Fig. 1 House in San Antonio, Texas (photo by author)



Fig. 2 House in Wrightsville, Beach, North Carolina (photo by author)

Oliver Witte reported that in 1982 the United States had about 62,000 architects while accredited schools of architecture were graduating another 4,000 students a year.⁶ And although there are no firm figures on what percentage of buildings are actually designed by architects it would not be a mistake to surmise that there is still a large, untapped market of potential clients. Yet, to be capable of serving this diverse public new paradigms must be introduced and developed. "But you gotta know the territory," as one of the salesmen in *The Music Man* warned. Learning about the whole territory requires a better understanding of the basis upon which both the old territory and the new territory exist. In architecture that means both the idea of traditionalism and the idea of modernism.

The Idea of Traditionalism

*First, to be a living language, it must be the shared vision of a group of people, very specific to their culture, able to capture their hopes and dreams, containing many childhood memories, and special local ways of doing things.*⁷

Christopher Alexander

Imagine a family beginning to set up a household. Maybe it's a family of squatters claiming a small piece of land on the edge of São Paulo or peasants constructing new courtyard housing on the outskirts of Beijing. Or maybe it's a family like your own moving into a newly purchased house—the one that your mother and father have been dreaming about since they first began their family. There is no mysterious process at work. A ritual of living already exists and the family arranges its spaces and locates its artifacts and memorabilia in such a manner as to support those rituals. Family life as the basis for the stability of every human being is still the strongest institution in society. And institutions with all their conventions, customs and underlying codes are validated by their past. We inherit them. They evolve because they are constantly being etched upon by the present. However, their structure, their fabric, exist in the past—in history. So the order of the household, the social uses of space as well as the privatization of territory, the hierarchies of spatial use, and the relationships between spaces are a function of the ritual of family life. The house is a stage upon which the family carries out its formal and informal rituals and ceremonies.

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Anthropologist Robert Redfield has pointed out that all societies are governed by a moral order and a technical order. These orders are two different means by which the activities of people are coordinated. Moral order according to Redfield, "refers to the organization of human sentiments into judgments as to *what is right*"⁸ (italics are mine). In folk societies this sense of rightness is guided by religion, but in more advanced societies or less religious ones rightness refers to a sense of social solidarity that arises out of common needs or a shared world-view. Technical order, on the other hand, is "that order which results from mutual usefulness . . ."⁹ It is bound by things and is characterized by necessity and expediency. Redfield suggests that folk societies are dominated by moral order while more advanced urbanized societies are dominated by technical order. Both orders exist to a degree in all societies.

It is the moral order which is pervasive in traditional society. Custom and prejudice shape lives and beliefs. Where strong tradition exists believing is seeing, not the other way around. Reason falls victim to habit. Precedent, prescription and repeated patterns determine behavior. The entire basis for Christopher Alexander's "pattern language" is the realization that there is a fluid code which not only generates each building, each room, each door, but also whole neighborhoods and towns.¹⁰ As it turns out this pattern language is grounded in tradition. The process of shaping houses, streets and gardens is commonplace and understood by everyone. And this process of shaping buildings is based on patterns of events in our everyday lives. These patterns have a formative effect on people's lives. Mayer Spivak, in an article entitled "Archetypal Place,"¹¹ describes thirteen basic behavioral patterns (meet, sleep, eat, work, etc.) which vary in different periods in our lives. These patterns require particular places if the actions that they define are to be carried out. Without the appropriate place, setting deprivation occurs. These patterns also are all culturally relative and it is the purpose of culture to transmit them.¹² Although all cultures are transformed by both internal and external forces, most anthropologists would agree that it is a continuity through time which makes for a stable culture.

The goal of culture is to make life secure and enduring for its members.¹³ To this end culture exploits the environment. In this respect important functions of culture are to satisfy people's psychological and spiritual needs, to help its members through the use of ideology, ritual and ceremony to keep and transmit meanings. One way that this is accomplished is through dwelling. Christian Norberg-Schulz, in *Genius Loci*, established the concept of dwelling as a synonym for "existential foothold." He is most convincing when he says that: "Man dwells when he can orientate himself within and identify himself with an environment or, in short, when he experiences the environment as meaningful."¹⁴ Familiar shapes and traditional forms are meaningful because of their associations with cultural patterns. So when your family finally inhabits that dream house it is no wonder that a strong sense of identity as a family becomes closely attached to that room, to the window that looks out over the garden, to the nook where the family eats and shares the day's events or to the sense of shelter that the roof provides. We recognize that as architects one of our roles should be in helping people to realize, achieve and celebrate those patterns and rituals. Yet as Kouwenhoven has pointed out, tradition is not as static as it is made out to be. Cultures drift and evolve. While standards might originate in the past, it is the present that pulls the past forward, constantly influencing old standards and introducing new ones. How many times have we heard people say, "they just don't build houses like they used to?" This could be interpreted several ways. First, it could mean that construction standards are changing, that craftsmanship has deteriorated, that materials are lower in quality and more likely to break down and that the house itself is smaller and less ornate. But it could also mean, "I wish they would build houses with qualities like the ones they used to build"—perhaps a more deeply rooted desire to dwell in a house like that of one's childhood memories. (Fig. 3) When compared to the houses of one's memory, today's tract houses only superficially seem to preserve family patterns.

The relationship between the past and the present is not dead. At the same time that he defended tradition by calling it the "drapery of life" Edmund Burke advocated change as the process of modifying past

injustices.¹⁵ And today, precedent is constantly being distorted by new circumstances. Again, looking to Kouwenhoven, we recognize that his definition of vernacular includes the dynamics of change. He refers to the fact that much of what the rest of the world calls American civilization is "that often untidy vernacular ferment produced when the technology of manufactured power and the democratic spirit work together."¹⁶ Yet he is cautious to distinguish the cultivated tradition, which maintained a stubborn reliance on the past while justifying its present through the theory of "taste,"¹⁷ from the vernacular tradition, which developed more freely. But more on this idea of a dynamic tradition later.

Marshall McLuhan's "global village" and William Irwin Thompson's "meta-industrial village," both created by modern communications technology and high speed transportation systems, are based in the traditions of the past but use the technologies of the future. Today we live in many worlds, some narrow and traditional, others wide and modern. Standards of quality and historical precedent are constant only in their continual reinterpretation and revision. While we may be anxious to hold on to the past and to embrace the traditions of our culture, we are also dragged into the future by the forces of modernity and our desire as architects to be at the forefront of change.

The Idea of Modernism

While tradition defines, limits and establishes a sense of fixed social rightness and order, Modernism advocates the eclipse of accepted truths and traditional values. Modernism has its roots in the social, political and industrial revolutions which began in the late-eighteenth century. It is a force for a more egalitarian, more politicized world. It is a force which changes the world by changing the way we look at the world. In other words it alters the base upon which our values and standards are established.

The ideology of Modernism, in challenging accepted sentiments and conventions offers an aesthetic of constant renewal; it is always fresh, always challenging, often unpredictable and inconclusive. For example, Colin Rowe has pointed out that modern architecture's preoccupation with the outer angle, the "problems of the built solid" or the building as "insulated object" (Fig. 4) contrasts sharply with the

traditional concern for the passive and enclosing inner angle and the structure of space over object.¹⁸ Such a reorientation of focus meant that modern space was seen as dynamic and flowing where traditional space was conceived as static, fixed and immutable; both concepts connected directly to the existing world-views of their time. As Rowe has shown, in LeCorbusier's centerless Villa Savoye there is a spatial dynamic which moves up and through the building to its outside edge, while Palladio's Villa Capra-Rotonda provides a clearly defined, fixed internal center.¹⁹ In similar ways the architecture of emerging Modernism challenged other values. Philip Johnson's Glass House challenged the concept of spatial boundary and the American iconology of house and Charles and Ray Eames challenged the classical idea of a fixed relationship of parts by using industrial materials in an interchangeable and fluid manner.

The literary critic Irving Howe has observed of the culture of Modernism and its impact on the arts:

"The consequences are extreme: a break-up of the traditional unity and continuity of Western culture, so that the decorums of its past no longer count for very much in determining its present, and a loosening of those ties which, in one or another way, had bound it to the institutions of society over the centuries."²⁰

The educational philosophy at the Bauhaus exploited the idea of Modernism and exported its techniques and way of thinking to the rest of Western society. The Bauhaus promoted the liberation of the individual's creative spirit by breaking down conventional patterns of thought. Bauhaus educators accused most contemporary artists of losing touch with new methods and materials, of becoming weak, sentimental slaves to narrow conventions. All existing dogmas were rejected. The principles of tradition or style were transcended in search for universal and eternal principles based in reason. This, it might be argued, is the *true* sense of tradition; the historical sense which T. S. Eliot suggests "... involves a perception, not only of the pastness of the past, but of its presence; ..."²¹ It is, according to Eliot, a sense of the timeless and the temporal together. These abstract principles were the basis upon which Gro-



Fig. 3 House in Cincinnati, Ohio (photo by author)

pius, Itten, Kandinsky, Meyer, Mies and others taught. Beyond the Bauhaus, CIAM, with its Athens Charter, challenged traditional principles of town-planning.

The Modernist viewpoint brought with it a new rational process of design, one which analyzed "problems" and synthesized "solutions." Every design opportunity was a chance for a fresh and original approach. Architects, fired by the technological spirit of the age, purged their minds of the historical past in order to tackle each new situation without prejudice. Local values, regional characteristics, orthodox building techniques and existing codes for interpreting built form lost their importance when faced with the expressive, aesthetic and formal values of this new attitude. Where traditions could be seen as evolutionary, Modernism was revolutionary.

Faced with both the force of traditionalism and the force of Modernism how do we as architects and educators develop paradigms which respond to either situation? Is it possible to conceive of different paradigms which might address either condition? Or does a paradigm exist for addressing both conditions concurrently? Finally, which attitude might be most appropriate for the design of a vernacular architecture?



Fig. 4 Administration Building, Wayne State University, Detroit, Glen Paulsen, architect (photo by author)



Fig. 5 Mars Hill, North Carolina (photo by author)

Three Approaches

Given the anthropological model of society as a unified phenomenon combining both surface characteristics and an underlying deep structure, Umberto Eco poses three possible approaches for building. First, he suggests that the architect's "attitude could be one of thoroughly integrating his work into the reigning social system." Second, the architect could "dispose with the conventional architecture and oblige the people to live with a totally different architecture." In the third approach the architect "could undertake to create an architecture that would be new but that would be intended to answer to that basic code" which governs a particular society.²²

Each approach is influenced by the ideologies of traditionalism or Modernism in varying degrees. In addition, each method varies in its response to the problem of a vernacular architecture. Although Eco is interested in the semiotic possibilities of architecture, his three approaches or positions with respect to the society of users is eminently suitable to the kinds of questions that both architects and educators constantly face.

The first approach, that of integrating the architectural task into the reigning social system, is a distinctly conservative position. Eco suggests that the architect would design "buildings to permit the way of life to which the members of society are accustomed, with no thought of upsetting it in any way."²³ Technical codes as well as social codes would be understood and honored. To accomplish this we would have to be taught to recognize that a stable social order was in existence and that the institutions of society had clear roles to uphold and responsibilities to carry out. We would need to understand the order of existing architectural elements and how they support social and cultural actions. Perhaps this order could be described as a "messy vitality," to use Robert Venturi's words, but there would be an awareness of a state of agreement between the buildings and their surroundings. Small towns in America have these characteristics. In fact, rural areas around the world often seem untouched by the kind of architectural sophistication that exists in urban areas. (Fig. 5)

In such a conservative, traditional society the role of the architect would be to understand the way of life as it is, the generative possibilities present in the grammar of the architectural elements in use, and the conventional methods of building. In this case, architecture, as Eco suggests, is "not the field of creative freedom some have imagined it to be, but a system of rules for giving society what it expects in the way of architecture."²⁴ Note that "expects" does not mean "wants." Architects would provide a service to society in much the same way as the neighborhood mechanic, the grocer, the local medical clinic or the building contractor. This should not in the least demean the role of the architect. Rather, it places the architect directly among the important contributing members of society. That is, if we believe that what an architect has to offer, i.e., a heightened awareness of human experience through the articulation of architectural elements, is a necessity for a full life, then what will be required is a complete reorganization of the delivery system of architectural services. The true measure is not in architecture's originality but in its quality. Learning to search for quality relieves us from the pressure to be original when originality is uncalled for.

At first glance this approach might appear to be the least creative. Yet, in addition to the well-known work of Christopher Alexander and the Center for Environmental Structure and that of Hassan Fathy, there are other works of design which, through the study of existing living patterns, attempt to develop an architecture that accommodates rather than changes such patterns. Examples range from a revitalization of a French neighborhood²⁵ to spatial studies of informal housing in India²⁶ to studies of the relationship between socially and culturally determined behavior and house design in urban neighborhoods in Kenya.²⁷ Much of the research work of American sociologist Herbert Gans also supports this first approach.

This first method, which seeks not to disturb a society's expectations, bases its architecture right in the center of that society's cultural values. If a true vernacular architecture is to exist and the architect is to be a contributor to its development, then architects must literally move in amongst those for whom they are providing services, much like the old country

doctor. Following this approach would require the architect to give up any pretensions of being original in design work and concentrate on being good. The architect would have to learn to see things as they are and to aim to create poetry out of the everyday (Fig. 6). This first approach falls clearly, it seems, within the realm of tradition. Most of the buildings built in the world today are constructed in societies with traditional values. Even the majority of American society has traditional values. Look at your family's own home and those homes of your family's friends. How else can we account for a reawakened interest in historical architecture but that people recognize and prefer buildings that have character, identity and are formally and symbolically accessible?

Yet as I have suggested earlier, the idea of Modernism is still the dominant paradigm in both the practice of architecture and in architectural education. Even Post Modernism with its promotion of a more pluralist philosophy, is mainly characterized by modernist ideology.

The second approach runs parallel to the nature of Modernism and aims to contrive an architecture which dispenses with the customary patterns of life to offer an alternative way of living, one which has little relation to existing social patterns, cultural values or accepted architectural forms. According to this method, the architect remakes the world into a new image of a more desirable future—a revolutionary alternative future. Often this image is created as a criticism of existing aesthetic standards or social mores. Following the dictum of Modernism, this approach, one that Eco refers to as "avant-garde subversiveness," defies nearly every existing architectural code. There is little reference to a repertoire of known forms, patterns of organization are unique and methods of construction are unorthodox. Architectural form is self reflexive; that is, the form itself becomes the content. Modernism aimed to focus attention on the purely aesthetic, to remove historical associations and to ask the reader to see past immediate phenomena in a new and more revealing way.

Modern architects saw a new society emerging from the ashes of World War I; a society motivated by new democratic principles, by the new technologies of

mass production brought on by the Industrial Revolution, by new materials like reinforced concrete, high-strength steel and glass, by the rise of the middle class and by new forms of communication and transportation. They saw that old forms of architecture and old, traditional cities were entirely incapable of supporting the modern life implied by all these events. Modern architects focused their visions far into the future past the havoc and destruction caused by WWI. Rebuilding Europe without the fetters of tradition and the past was the goal. The spirit of the age was the spirit of Modernism. Yet this is not the point. The question, as posed earlier, is can the Modernist ideology provide a basis for the understanding and designing of a vernacular architecture or does Modernism run counter to the basis upon which vernacular architecture exists? To reflect genuinely the spirit of Modernism while at the same time satisfying the traditional prerogatives for a vernacular architecture seems both unreasonable and improbable. In a shrinking world, why should architecture be bound by the constraints of geographic idiosyncrasies? Technological and economic considerations appear more dominant than formal considerations. Building components manufactured in Belgium are assembled in Beijing. Mobile homes fabricated in Indiana are delivered and erected in Tennessee. With modern technology in environmental conditioning, ideal interior climatic conditions can be created without regard to local conditions. National economic planning and central authority in socialist states balance regional inequities. Federal entitlement programs and subsidies tend to level uneven distributions in democratic societies. Multi-national corporations spread their products and their image over world-wide markets. Even functional distinctions get hazy since most buildings change usage a number of times during their life span.

Most importantly, it is the ideology of Modernism and the nature of its agent, the avant garde, which rule out the creation of vernacular architecture using a Modernist ideology. Robert Venturi, one of the architects whose work and writing broke through the boundaries created by modern architecture considers his practice to be elitist.²⁸ Venturi's work is guided by theoretical constructs; constructs which, like orthodox modern architecture, create an intellectual atmosphere. His ref-

erences, precedents or "quotes" are derived from an array of buildings that lie outside of the experience of most of his community of users. His practice, like most of the more highly publicized practices today, could be called esoteric; it is designed and understood only by the initiated. In an esoteric practice a set of ideas and an associated formal language, one that could be called elitist, mediates the design process.

When one is forced to choose between the ideological codes of Modernism or those of traditionalism, which are necessary to generate a true, valid vernacular, it is Modernism that is usually chosen. This is so because the Modernist ideology most closely approximates the view that architecture is a change agent and therefore must be in the advance guard of architectural evolution. But most architectural students enter their educational programs with a middle-class upbringing and the architectural educational system, rather than broadening the available paradigms, tends to shrink them. In other words, students are not taught when the Modernist ideology might be appropriate. Instead, they replace their own traditional set of values with a Modernist set, a set still embedded in our texts, journals, studio exercises, educational methodology and curricula.

But Eco offers a third approach, one which, if we read between the lines, he advocates. This third approach or paradigm aims to link the basic codes and conventions of society with the implications for the community brought on by new developments. Its goal is to produce an architecture that would be understood and accepted because its basis exists within the framework of social and aesthetic expectations. At the same time this architecture would anticipate cultural, technological and economic changes; systems over which the architect has no direct influence.

Eco is particularly concerned that the architect's creativity is not compromised. He would like the architect to be free enough to find "some way in which to make a church that, while conforming to its type, would be somewhat different from any that had yet appeared . . ."²⁹ His key point is that architecture, or for that matter any sign system, can "institute moments of high information content, but

only when they are supported by a certain amount of redundancy."³⁰ This means that a creative move can be made only when it exists within a recognized field. So the architect and the student of architecture must first be taught to recognize and understand the characteristics of the existing codes, those with which a society identifies, before proposing suggestions for a new architecture.

If any approach can satisfy the demands of both traditionalism and Modernism, this is the one. It is the only method which can respond to the question of continuity in a vernacular architecture, whether that architecture happens to exist in America or a third-world nation. Certainly the work of Irving Gill, (Fig. 7) in southern California in the early part of this century, satisfied this requirement of being both regionally distinct while also anticipating changes in construction technology, especially the use of poured-in-place tilt-up concrete walls. Maybeck's work in the San Francisco Bay area with new materials was always experimental and the Greene brothers carried on the tradition of the southern California stick and bungalow style while setting new standards for wood detailing. Such evidence would lead us to believe that changes in technology occur at a more rapid pace than changes in social and cultural values. Although this is not an earth-shaking or novel conclusion, it does suggest a more temperate approach to design. If the typical projects published in the architectural journals are any indication it seems that

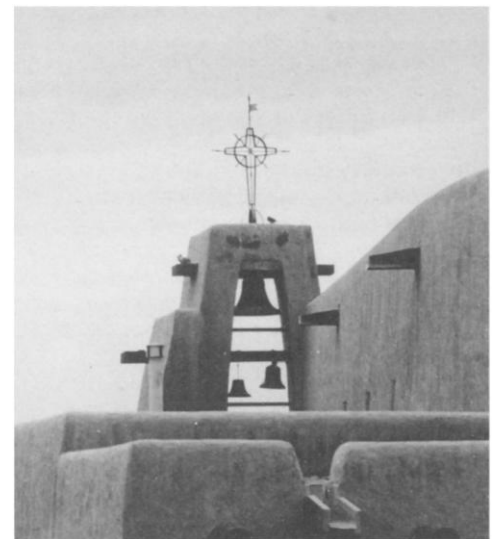


Fig. 6 Church, Taos, New Mexico (photo by author)

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Fig. 7 Women's Club, La Jolla, California, Irving Gill, architect (photo by author)



Fig. 8 Greek Orthodox Church near Epidaurus, Greece. New reinforced concrete technology and traditional forms (photo by author)

most architects are far more competent when they rely on tradition than when they try to be original. I say this with no cynicism intended because this approach to design is precisely what architects have been doing for centuries, and doing well at it.

When Christian Norberg-Schulz calls for the "recovery of place,"³¹ he doesn't mean a return to a romantic historicism, an abstract formalism or a pseudo-classicism. He means the creation of an architecture that possesses figural character in relation to the landscape, has a clear and well-defined sense of place, has a social inside and outspoken local character. He feels that a theory of place unites modern architecture with the past and satisfies the demand for continuity. A true and enduring architecture springs from the full understanding of a way of life concretized in its entirety in architectural form. (Fig. 8) This might be what Aldo Van Eyck meant in *Team Ten Primer* when he said that architecture is the built counterform of society.³² His own infatuation with the Dogon people in the Atlas Mountains of Africa was influenced by their keen sense of wholeness as a society.

So this third approach, that of marrying a new architecture with the basic codes of society might hold the only possible source of hope based on the realities of existing architectural education and practice.

Conclusion

The realities of architectural education revolve around the idea of shared paradigms. Thomas Kuhn introduced the idea of shared paradigms into the scientific community.³³ He said that a community's paradigms are revealed in its textbooks, lectures and laboratory exercises. For architects the studio is comparable to the laboratory. The studio is still the dominant mode of learning in architectural education. Recurring illustrations of various "theories" and their applications exist in this model form of learning. In addition, the classics of architecture, what we call precedents, supply the foundation for defining the legitimate concerns of architecture.

Paradigms are much fuzzier than a full set of rules. They include the philosophical positions and points of view of the faculty their selection of literature, the fashions and trends of the currently honored architects, the recognized exemplars and achievements from the past interpreted by

historians and critics, and the affinities of students. Kuhn suggested that even though it may not be possible to produce a full interpretation or rationalization of a paradigm it does not prevent the paradigm from guiding research or design. Following Kuhn's lead then, it could be deduced that architecture students never learn concepts for designing buildings in the abstract. These concepts, theories and methods are always learned and solidified through the studio experience.

Contemporary architectural education shows a distinct concern for the immediate context, for historical precedent, for user needs and for energy conservation. Students are taught to deal with the present as well as anticipate the future. But beneath this surface still lies the Modernist paradigm, which continues to reward in student work inventive cleverness and novelty over sensitivity to society's traditions. As long as the existing paradigm leans solely towards the Modern architects will never be able to understand, let alone respond, when a vernacular architecture might be called for. Most schools of architecture are too out of touch with what John Stilgoe has called the "common knowledge"³⁴ which has governed spatial design in America since its founding. This "common knowledge" is a mixture of both local vernacular values and high-style imported values. When the paradigm of education turns toward this common knowledge, the potential for architects to participate in the design of a vernacular architecture might be possible.

What seems to be overlooked ultimately in Eco's three approaches is that all three are appropriate at one time or another. Teaching one method at the expense of the other two robs a student of the capacity to respond to each situation as the situation demands. Furthermore it forces the practitioner into an established pattern of design which either becomes outdated or is inappropriate. Having a working knowledge of all these approaches coupled with the keen ability to judge each occasion on its own terms will provide both the student and the practitioner with a more complete set of paradigms from which to design.

Notes

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